Jared Ren

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Research interests: Human-AI interaction; how frontline practitioners and the public negotiate the integration of novel computational tools into everyday and professional practice; AI-mediated communication; participatory and community-engaged design; AI for the public sector and social good; future of work.

EDUCATION

University of Washington, Seattle, WA — Expected June 2027

M.S., Human Centered Design and Engineering (HCDE) — GPA 4.0/4.0

University of Toronto, Toronto, ON — June 2024

Hon. B.A. with High Distinction, Sociology and East Asian Studies

PUBLICATIONS

Ren, J., & Cho, S. "ChatGPT, Review This Message to My Prof": Investigating Students' Use of AI for Online Communication in Academic Settings. *Poster, ACM Conference on Computer-Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing (CSCW 2026).* Accepted. **(First author.)**

Ren, J., & Cho, S. Full-length manuscript extending the above study (interview sample n = 15). *In preparation*, target August 2026.

PRESENTATIONS

- Capstone field-research presentation — community-based study, Pune, India.
- Cultural-exchange presentation — Japan exchange program.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

AI in Academic Online Communication — *First-authored interview study (CSCW 2026 poster)* — 2026

- Designed and led an IRB-approved, two-phase semi-structured interview study (12 participants across multiple North American universities, recruited via institutional, network, and snowball sampling) on why and how students use AI for academic messaging.
- Ran a digital-whiteboard elicitation and in-depth walkthroughs; produced 110 recipient-channel groups consolidated into 31 recurring contexts.
- Conducted sentence-level open coding and iterative thematic analysis with the team until a typology of AI-use orientations stabilized; extending the analysis into a full manuscript (n = 15).

Wikipedia Dispute-Classification Tool — *Directed Research, UW* — Jan–Apr 2026

- Built an LLM-powered tool to help Wikipedia moderators rapidly identify each talk-page dispute's main topic and applicable policy, reducing the cognitive overhead moderators flagged as their primary bottleneck.
- Parsed and data-logged 170+ talk-page discussions, extracting thousands of individual messages and hand-labeling each to the relevant Wikipedia policy, essay, or guideline.
- Validated inter-rater agreement with a teammate, then fine-tuned OpenAI GPT-4o mini in Python to predict dispute topic and primary policy; delivered a functioning prototype for moderator testing.

Professional Visual Artists & Generative AI — *Qualitative Research, HCDE 519* — Spring 2026

- Team interview study of how professional artists maintain creative identity, authorship, and agency as generative AI enters their workflow; led paper architecture, findings tables, quote verification, and advisor-meeting memos.
- Performed iterative thematic analysis in ATLAS.ti, building a 68-code codebook; framed the core contribution distinguishing proactive, principle-based limits from reactive, quality-based fixes.

Orcasound × The Whale Museum — *UX Research Intern* — 2026–present

- Conducting discovery research for the redesign of the "Sound of the Salish Sea" bioacoustics exhibit (Friday Harbor, WA), representing the nonprofit Orcasound.
- Running stakeholder interviews, structured field observation (AEIOU), and in-field intercept interviews; synthesizing findings across in-person site visits.

Neighborhood Farmers Markets — *Community-Based Participatory Design* 2026–present

- Co-designed a playful "map your route" activity and sticker cultural probes to surface market-goers' awareness of food-access currency programs (EBT, SNAP Market Match, Fresh Bucks).
- Collected and analyzed 26 participant worksheets (route, dwell-time, and awareness data); scaling the method toward a participatory-design conference poster and a reusable community handoff blueprint.

SELECTED PROJECTS & TOOLS

TraceQual — *AI-disclosure tool for qualitative analysis* 2026

- Built a tool that reads a researcher–AI chat transcript and produces a structured decision matrix documenting each analytic choice, for use in a methods appendix or audit trail.
- Implemented in Python with the Anthropic Messages API; versioned schema grounded in the qualitative-methods literature, a rule-derived confidence model, and a four-state validation harness; packaged as a Jupyter notebook with a Streamlit/Hugging Face deployment path. github.com/jaredren/tracequal

Computational Methods coursework — *HCDE 530* 2026

- Collected data from public APIs, analyzed it with Python/pandas, coded chat data for sentiment and themes, and produced data visualizations with matplotlib and Plotly for data storytelling.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Continuous Improvement Intern — *Seattle City Light, Civic Innovation* Summer 2026

- Full-time civic-innovation internship supporting process-improvement work at a municipal electric utility, with a focus on frontline public-sector practice.

UX & Service Design Researcher — *Canada Revenue Agency, Government of Canada* Jun 2024–Aug 2025

- Led public-sector UX research, conducting 50+ user interviews and usability sessions to improve digital services for small-business taxpayers.
- Drove service redesigns that increased traffic by 25% and task-success rate by 66%; ran tree-testing studies that informed navigation for 10,000+ small-business users.

INTERNATIONAL RESEARCH & STUDY

- Community-based capstone field research — Pune, India.
- Summer study exchange — Tokyo, Japan.

HONORS & AWARDS

- Munk Student Excellence Award
- Kakehashi Project Award (Japan-funded cultural exchange)
- East Asian Studies Chinese Language Citation
- Dean's List

TECHNICAL & RESEARCH SKILLS

Programming & data: Python (pandas), data wrangling, exploratory and descriptive analysis, Git/GitHub, Jupyter.

NLP & ML: LLM APIs (Anthropic, OpenAI), prompt engineering, GPT-4o mini fine-tuning.

Qualitative methods: semi-structured interviews, thematic analysis and codebook development, contextual inquiry, field observation (AEIOU), intercept interviews, participatory / community-based design, cultural probes; usability testing (moderated, cognitive walkthrough, heuristic evaluation).

Quantitative methods: survey design, Likert and SUS instruments, descriptive statistics.

Data visualization: matplotlib, Plotly; data storytelling.

Tools: ATLAS.ti, Figma, Streamlit/Gradio, Excel.

LANGUAGES

English (fluent) · Mandarin (intermediate) · Japanese (intermediate, JLPT N4) · French (conversational)